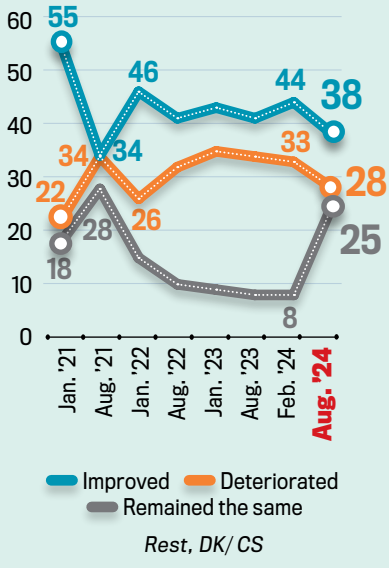
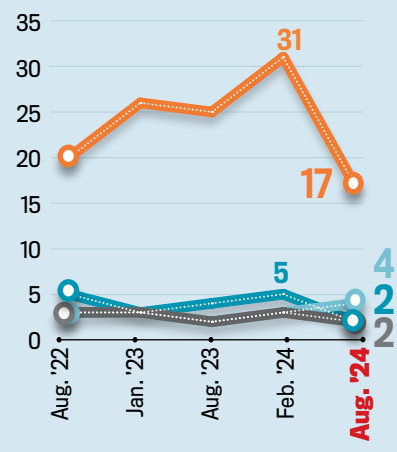
Q. Has communal harmony improved under the NDA-ruled Union government?



Rest, DK/ CS

There's a 6-percentage point drop in those who feel communal harmony has improved

Q. If communal harmony in India has deteriorated, who do you think is responsible for it?



Rest, DK/ CS

Those who blame BJP-RSS for the deteriorating communal harmony have nearly halved

Q. Do you feel free to express your opinion on politics and religion?



Rest, others & DK/ CS

All figures in % and rounded off

mony under the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-led Union government is also somewhat mixed. Only 37.9 per cent of the respondents think it has improved. Their share was over 41 per cent in the previous five surveys, having notched 45.4 per cent in the January 2022 MOTN. Those who think it has deteriorated account for 28.1 per cent, according to the August 2024 MOTN, while the perception that it has remained the same has almost trebled to 25.4 per cent from single digits in the earlier four polls.

Significantly, though the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its ideological parent, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), are still reckoned to be primarily responsible for the deterioration in communal harmony, the perception is on a decline. Only 17.1 per cent of the respondents think so now, from 31 per cent just six months ago. Meanwhile, only 2.2 per cent feel that the Opposition parties are responsible for such deterioration. In fact, 3.8 per cent of the respondents blame mainstream and social media.

Farmers' challenges persist, and though there is official and political intervention from time to time, especially around elections, their hapless plight is evident as an overwhelming 86.6 per cent of the respondents believe the government should legally guarantee minimum support prices (MSP) for agricultural produce. This unwavering faith in state intervention persists despite initiatives like eNAM, or National Agriculture Market, to regulate pricing and promote seamless marketing.

An equally nagging concern is the state of the environment and the inadequacy of measures being taken for its protection. Those who feel such measures are completely insufficient account for 24 per cent of the respondents, up from 21.1 per cent in the January 2023 MOTN. But in the same period, the percentage of respondents who felt measures to protect the environment are wholly or partially adequate has risen from 67.1 to 70.9.

Given the recent spate of train mishaps and videos of rowdy passengers being circulated on social media, the MOTN respondents for the first time were asked whether the Indian Railways—the fourth largest network in the world with a running track length of over 100,000 kilometres—has done enough to make rail travel safe for its 11 billion annual passengers. The opinion is sharply divided. While 40.4 per cent of the respondents feel it has done enough, 43.6 per cent say it hasn't. Something the railway ministry should pay heed to. ■